Vishnupriya Devi

Вишнуприя-деви · @vishnupriya

Mistress of Gaura's Home

Vishnupriya Devi is the second consort of Sri Chaitanya Mahaprabhu and the mistress of His home in Navadvipa. She came into Gaura-lila to assist the Lord in His foremost work — the preaching of the holy name — and after His sannyasa she remained in Navadvipa for many years as a living example of how to worship the name in separation from Him. She has many names and titles: Vishnupriya Devi, Vishnupriya Thakurani, “Vishnupriya-ma”; in the “Prema-vilasa” and the “Bhakti-ratnakara” she is Ishvari, “the Queen”; she is called the Mother of the world (jaganmata), Lakshmi and Mahalakshmi, Narayani, Parameshvari, or simply Priya — “the Beloved.” The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” calls her “Lakshmi, the Mother of the world,” and in the childhood prayer of Srinivasa quoted in the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (2.176–180) the Lord is glorified as “the husband of Lakshmi and Vishnupriya.”

The primary sources say little about her. Already in the list of pastimes with which the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” opens, Vrindavana Dasa mentions her marriage:

“In the Adi-khanda the Lord's consort (Lakshmipriya) leaves the world, and the Lord marries a second time — the daughter of the Raja Pandita (Vishnupriya).” (CB, Adi 1.110)

The wedding itself he describes in detail in the fifteenth chapter of the Adi-khanda. Krishnadasa Kaviraja in the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” records it in a single line:

“Then Nimai married Vishnupriya, the goddess of fortune.” (CC, Adi 16.25)

He passes at once to the Lord's victory over the digvijayi; beyond this the “Charitamrita” says not a word about Vishnupriya. The matchmaking and the wedding are described by Murari Gupta in his “Kadacha” (first prakrama, sargas 13–14), and in particular detail by Lochana Dasa in the “Chaitanya-mangala” (Adi-khanda, parts 13–14); in Lochana Dasa's poem Vishnupriya appears in many other places as well, and at its very beginning, among the invocations, he glorifies her:

“I glorify Vishnupriya-ma, [the queen] of Navadvipa: her ornament is the Lord's crimson feet.” (CM, Sutra-khanda, part 1, v. 22)

The Daughter of the Raja Pandita

Vishnupriya's father was Sanatana Mishra, a brahmana of Navadvipa and an exalted devotee of Vishnu. All the virtues that accompany vishnu-bhakti lived in him: a gentle heart, straightforwardness, truthfulness, mastery of the senses, readiness to help, generosity and hospitality. Of high birth and great nobility, very wealthy and influential in worldly and public affairs, he maintained many people, feeding and clothing them and giving them shelter. He was known as the “raja-pandita” — the court pandita, “king of panditas”; so the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” too calls him, naming Vishnupriya “the daughter of the Raja Pandita.” In social standing he was above Nimai's family[1]. Vishnupriya's grandfather was named Durgadasa Mishra[2]; according to the “Prema-vilasa,” the descendants of Durgadasa's line through Yadavacharya are known as “Vishnupriya's parivara” — her family.

For his pure devotion to Vishnu, Sanatana was granted a daughter rich in every good quality — uncommonly gentle and well-mannered, like Lakshmi in person. Devotion to her parents and to Vishnu marked her from earliest childhood; three times a day she went to bathe in the Ganga[3]; she kept strictly to the injunctions of scripture, performed puja and archana, served tulasi and observed many vows — from her very first years her life was service to Vishnu.

She appeared on the fifth lunar day of the bright fortnight of the month of Magha — shukla-panchami, or Sri-panchami. The same day is Sarasvati's festival, when those who seek mastery of worldly learning worship the goddess of knowledge. Yet there are two kinds of knowledge — apara, which concerns this world, and para, which transcends it — and Vishnupriya is honoured as the goddess and mistress of transcendent knowledge, para-vidya. The day of her appearance was determined by Jagannatha Dasa Babaji; he revealed it anew to the world through Bhaktivinoda Thakura, and, as the "Sarasvati-jaya-shri" writes, from Bhaktivinoda the custom of honouring her on this day spread through the whole Vaishnava world. The year of her birth, like the year of her departure, has not been preserved; we know only that she was born in Navadvipa, in her father's house.

As a girl, whenever she met Shachi Devi at the bathing ghat on the Ganga, Vishnupriya humbly bowed down to her, and Shachi blessed her: "By Krishna's mercy may you obtain a worthy husband." The Lord's mother secretly wished to have her as her daughter-in-law, and when she learned that this was the daughter of Sanatana Mishra, knowing her good qualities, she gladly embraced the thought of such a marriage.

The Matchmaking

The Lord's first consort, Lakshmipriya, left the world while He was travelling in East Bengal. On His return the Lord consoled His mother with instruction. For a long time pain tormented Shachi's heart, but in time she began to think of her son's happiness, and, having made sure that Gaurasundara was not unwilling, she took the matter seriously in hand and resolved to have Him married again.

She sent a servant for Kashinatha Pandita, a well-known matchmaker of Navadvipa — in Krishna-lila, according to the "Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika" (50), the brahmana whom King Satrajit sent to Krishna to propose the marriage of Satyabhama[4]. Shachi herself put the match to him: "Speak to the raja-pandita; if he wishes, let him give his daughter to my Nimai." Yet she was anxious whether so eminent a man would give his daughter to the son of poor parents, who was reputed to be eccentric besides. "Thakurani," the matchmaker replied, "if not to Nimai Pandita, to whom else should he give her?" Delighted, he promised to arrange everything quickly and set off at once for Sanatana's house, repeating the name of Hari.

Sanatana, for his part, had long desired this marriage. Seeing his daughter come of age, he had been looking for a bridegroom and had decided that none could be found better than Nimai Pandita — in beauty, in qualities and in years; a strong wish to give his daughter to Nimai grew in his heart, and he prayed to Hari: "If I have any merit from past births, let my daughter become the wife of Nimai Pandita." Kashinatha arrived just as Sanatana and his wife were talking in private about their daughter's marriage. The host seated his guest, offered him sweetened water and, taking the arrival of the famous matchmaker as a good omen, asked: "Pandita, what news?"

Vrindavana Dasa gives the matchmaker's answer thus:

"Give your daughter in marriage to Vishvambhara Pandita. I consider them a perfect pair. Vishvambhara is a worthy husband for your daughter, and your daughter is a worthy wife for Vishvambhara. The union of Vishnupriya and Nimai Pandita will be perfect, like the union of Krishna and Rukmini." (CB, Adi 15.57–59)

Sanatana and his wife were almost beside themselves with joy: the Lord, the Supersoul, knew their innermost wish and fulfilled it Himself. Sanatana took counsel with his wife, relatives and friends, and all agreed that the wedding should be held as soon as possible. "Of course I will give my daughter to Nimai Pandita," he told the matchmaker; "it will increase the good fortune of my whole family. Go and assure them." Kashinatha returned to Shachi and told her everything, and she answered: "I have done all

I could; the rest is in the hands of Sri Hari." Until then Nimai had known nothing; when everything was settled His mother told Him, and He consented, and the people of Navadvipa rejoiced to hear that Nimai Pandita was to marry.

Murari Gupta and Lochana Dasa add how the agreement was sealed. After waiting a few days, Sanatana himself sent a brahmana to Shachi to say that he was ready to give his daughter to Vishvambhara; Shachi gladly replied that she had long desired this union, and the delighted messenger foretold that, gaining such a husband, Vishnupriya would make her name — "dear to Vishnu" — true, and Vishvambhara would be as blissful as Krishna on obtaining Rukmini ("Kadacha" 1.13.8–15). In Lochana Dasa he says:

"Vishnupriya will obtain a husband like Vishvambhara — and the name Vishnupriya ('beloved of Vishnu') will become true for her. As Rukmini obtained Sri Krishna as her husband, so it will be with her." (CM, Adi-khanda, part 13, vv. 40–41)

The Wedding

The Lord's students rejoiced to hear of the wedding. All the expenses were taken on by Buddhimanta Khan — a neighbour and devoted follower of the Lord, a wealthy and wise friend of His family, one of the richest men of Navadvipa. Mukunda-Sanjaya, in whose chandimandapa Nimai kept His school, offered to share the costs, but Buddhimanta refused: this was to be no modest wedding of a poor brahmana, but one worthy of a prince. Nimai's students too helped to make it splendid. For this service Buddhimanta received Mahaprabhu's embrace and mercy.

An auspicious day and hour were chosen, and on the eve the adhivasa — the rite of preparation for the wedding — was performed with great pomp. The house was decorated with banana trees, full pitchers and mango leaves; lamps, unhusked rice and curd were set out, the ground was painted with alpana designs, and huge canopies were stretched. All the Vaishnavas, brahmanas and good people of Navadvipa were invited; people came from the neighbouring villages as well, and poets sang songs of their own composing about the bride and groom. By noon the mridangas, sanais, great drums and karatalas began to play; Vishnu was worshipped and arati performed. Such an adhivasa had never been seen in Navadvipa even among the rich, and people said they had never witnessed such a festival or such generosity to brahmanas.

The Lord Himself anointed the forehead of every brahmana and devotee with sandal paste, garlanded him and gave him betel. Some, greedy for gifts, joined the line again and again, but Gauranga ordered that each be given three times — and still the sandal, garlands and betel did not diminish; what fell on the ground alone would have sufficed for five weddings (cf. CB, Adi 15). Sanatana came too — with auspicious gifts, with relatives, friends and brahmanas, to music and singing — and anointed the Lord with fragrances (gandha-adhivasa). Gaurasundara performed the prescribed rites, worshipping Vishnu and the ancestors; Shachi with the women worshipped the Ganga and the goddess Shashthi and gave generously to the women — rice, bananas, ghee, betel and vermilion; by the Lord's power the gifts sufficed in abundance for all; Vishnupriya's mother too rejoiced with her neighbours. And the Lord bestowed food, cloth and wealth on the brahmanas, honouring each according to his worth.

The wedding ceremonies fell on the following day. Towards evening the devotees adorned the Lord: sandal paste and fragrant oils, a crescent of sandal on His forehead, a crown, garlands, garments, collyrium on His eyes, on His wrist a thread with rice and kusha grass, in His hand a banana leaf and a little mirror, golden earrings, bracelets and chains. Before setting out Gaurasundara bowed at the feet of His mother, the brahmanas and His teacher. The palanquin for the groom was prepared by Buddhimanta Khan, and his foot soldiers and servants walked behind it. First the Lord was carried to the Ganga; He

bathed and honoured Ganga Devi, and then, after midday, the groom in His palanquin was borne along the riverbank through the whole of Navadvipa to the bride's house. From every side rang out “Jaya! Jaya!” and the women's ulu-dhvani. Hundreds and thousands of torches and lamps lit the procession, fireworks soared and a rain of flowers fell; banners were carried, jesters and conjurors amused the crowd, dancers danced, countless instruments resounded, and children and old men alike broke into dance. Those who saw it said that neither Indra nor the Lord of Vaikuntha had such splendour, and brahmanas who had failed to marry their daughters to Nimai Pandita lamented a good fortune that comes but once in many lives.

At dusk, in the hour of godhuli, when the herds return home, the groom arrived at the house of Sanatana Mishra. Sanatana and his wife received their son-in-law with the varana rite and blessed Him; Sanatana helped the Lord down from the palanquin, led Him by the hand to the seat of honour, offered Him water to wash His feet, fragrance for the mouth, garments and ornaments. His wife with the women placed on the Lord's head a wreath of fresh ears of grain and kusha, performed arati with a seven-wicked lamp, sang hymns, showered Him with rice and blew the conch. All the rites were performed both according to the injunctions of the shastras and according to folk custom.

Then Vishnupriya, adorned with ornaments, was brought to the place of the wedding. Clad in silks and jewels she seemed a celestial maiden, while Nimai in His wedding attire outshone Cupid in beauty. Seven times she circled the Lord — her beloved Gaura-Narayana — and bowed at His feet. By custom bride and groom must look at each other for the first time, but in her natural modesty she could not raise her eyes to the Lord's face, and they were screened by a cloth so that the rite might take place in private. With that first glance they affirmed anew their eternal bond: as Lakshmi and Narayana are eternally inseparable, so Vishnupriya and Gaurasundara are eternally united.

Then they exchanged garlands. Vishnupriya first offered hers at the Lord's feet and placed it on Him, thereby giving herself to Him; the Lord, smiling, placed a garland on her, and the divine couple joyfully showered each other with flowers, while the gods headed by Brahma invisibly showered them with flowers from the heavens[5]:

“The Mother of the universe, Vishnupriya, offered the Lord a garland of flowers and bowed devotedly at His lotus feet. Smiling gently, the Lord also offered a garland to His bride. After this Lakshmi and Narayana joyfully began to shower each other with flowers.” (CB, Adi 15.176–178)

All eyes were fixed on the divine couple. The women gazed in admiration at Nimai, yet not one of them felt the least envy at Vishnupriya's good fortune, and in the women's quarters the ulu-dhvani and the sound of conches never ceased. Playful banter broke out between the families of the bride and groom, and the Lord's smile delighted everyone. Then Sanatana, having washed his feet and rinsed his mouth, performed the kanyadana — gave his daughter to the Lord — and with many gifts gave her dowry: many cows, land and servants. Vrindavana Dasa speaks of the meaning of this gift:

“Wishing to give pleasure to Lord Vishnu, Sanatana Mishra placed his daughter in the Lord's hands.” (CB, Adi 15.188)

After this the final fire sacrifice was performed, and the newly-weds were led to new chambers in the raja-pandita's mansion — that night Sanatana's house became Vaikuntha: Lakshmi and Narayana passed an auspicious night in the bridal chamber, on a bed adorned with flowers.

Sanatana was granted a good fortune known only to the Lord's great fathers-in-law — Janaka, who gave Sita to Rama, and Bhishmaka, who gave Rukmini to Krishna:

“Such great good fortune was obtained only by the greatest kings of the past: Nagnajit, Janaka, Bhishmaka and Jambavan. Now this good fortune fell to the lot of Sanatana Mishra and his family by

virtue of their unceasing service to Lord Vishnu.” (CB, Adi 15.195–196)

The next day, after midday, the divine couple set out for Shachi's house to music and singing; the bride rode in the palanquin together with her husband, and when Lakshmi sat beside the Lord, Shachi's house was filled with light and rejoicing[6]. The pious women of Navadvipa, looking at them, said:

“‘How fortunate she is! She must have served Lakshmi and Parvati for many lives.’ ‘They are exactly like Shiva and Parvati.’ — ‘These are Lakshmi and Lord Hari Themselves.’ ‘They are like Kamadeva and Rati.’ — ‘They are like Indra and Shachi.’ ‘I think They are Rama and Sita.’” (CB, Adi 15.205–208)

And Vrindavana Dasa concludes:

“Everyone who saw the Lord's wedding was cleansed of all sins and attained Vaikuntha.” (CB, Adi 15.216)

That is why, he adds, the Lord is called the All-merciful, the Lord of the fallen. The Lord's wedding is not a worldly union that binds a person to the world: it is the union of the Supreme Lord with His own energy. Therefore hearing of it does not bind but frees — both from maya and from the desire for worldly relations of “enjoyer” and “object of enjoyment,” for the only enjoyer is Narayana.

Life with the Lord in Navadvipa

Some time after the wedding the Lord, having completed His studies and now occupied with teaching, set out for Gaya (CM, Adi-khanda, part 15), and on His return from there He revealed to Navadvipa His love for Krishna. Of the years when kirtana resounded in Navadvipa the primary sources preserve little about Vishnupriya. When Mahaprabhu, in the house of Chandrashekhara Acharyaratna, played the role of Lakshmi in a sacred drama (CB, Madhya 18), Shachi came to watch Him together with Vishnupriya.

It is said that Vishvanatha Chakravarti, in his “remembrance of the eight periods of the day” of Gauranga, described a conversation of Gaura with Vishnupriya as well. Among the verses on His morning pastimes is this one: at the end of the night, hearing the cuckoos and the cocks, the Lord rose from His bed, delighted Vishnupriya with talk of rasa, went out, sat on the ground and washed His face together with good people, and His mother and relatives rejoiced to see Him. But even in this description the special character of the pastimes of Lakshmi and Gaura-Narayana — the pastimes of the Lord with His own energy in the home of a pious brahmana — is in no way violated.

The Night before Sannyasa

The “Chaitanya-bhagavata” does not relate the Lord's conversation with Vishnupriya before His sannyasa; it is described by Lochana Dasa — in detail, and with the tenderness that fills his whole poem. This account must be read as the account of the wedding is read: it is not a tale of worldly spouses being parted, but a pastime of Lakshmi and Gaura-Narayana. The Lord Himself directs it — and Himself prepares His bhu-shakti for the service that lies ahead of her, the service of separation.

Mother Shachi was the first to learn of her son's decision. She wished to tell her daughter-in-law what was in her heart, but could not utter a word — her face only grew wan, and tears streamed from her eyes. Vishnupriya herself had already heard what people were whispering, and from these hints she understood everything: “a thunderbolt fell out of season,” and she lost consciousness. At the close of day the Lord came home in haste, ate and lay down to rest, and Vishnupriya came to Him. Sighing, she sat by His lotus feet, laid them on her bosom, bound them with her arms and wept until her tears ran down His feet. Feeling this, the Lord rose:

“‘You are dear to Me as life — why do you weep? I want to know: answer Me, beloved.’ Setting her on His lap, taking her chin in His right hand, He asks in sweet words.” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, v. 6)

She said nothing and only wept, clasping His feet. Again and again the Lord questioned her in many ways, wiped her face with the edge of His cloth, began one tender, playful talk after another — “at such words even a stone would blossom” — until at last she spoke in a faltering voice:

“‘Listen, listen, Lord of my life, put Your hand on my head [and tell the truth]: are You really going to take sannyasa? Hearing it from people, I feel my heart will burst — I shall enter fire.’” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, v. 10)

For Him, she said, were her life and wealth, her beauty and youth; if He went away, what use was this wretched life? Her heart burned as with poison[7]. But then she spoke no longer of herself, but of Him:

“‘Shame on my body! One thing I ask You: how will You walk the roads on foot? Your feet are tender as shirisha flowers — my hand is afraid to touch them. When You stand on the ground, my heart quakes with fear and my whole body shudders; in the forests, among thorns, where will You go, to what lands? How will You walk on Your crimson feet?’” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, vv. 12–13)

At the slightest effort, she went on, drops of sweat appear on His face, and a sannyasi wanders now in downpour, now in scorching heat. To whom would He leave her? Shachi is old and half-dead — how could He leave such a mother? How could He leave Murari and Mukunda, Srivasa and Haridasa, Advaita Acharya? The whole world thinks Him a treasury of prema — would He cover everyone with disgrace? And at last:

“‘What shall I, worthless one, say? If I am the root of Your household life and You take sannyasa because of me — let me take Your misfortunes upon myself and die by taking poison, and You live happily in Your own home.’” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, v. 18)

In this plea there is not a word of her own enjoyment. Vishnupriya fears for His tender feet, for His aged mother, for the devotees, for His good name — and is ready to die herself, if only He need not suffer hardship. This is what pure devotees see in her: not a trace of the possessive desire that would stand in the way of the Lord's sannyasa.

Hearing her, Gauranga smiled, again took her onto His lap, wiped her face with His cloth and began to jest:

“‘Do not dwell on needless grief. That I will leave you and go to take sannyasa — who ever told you that? Whatever I do, when I do it, I shall tell you then — but now do not die of needless sorrow.’” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, vv. 20–21)

So, embracing her, in sweet and playful pastimes the Lord comforted Vishnupriya in every way[8]. Yet even when “in joyful play the night came to an end,” the fire in her heart was not quenched. At daybreak, gazing at the face of her Lord and pressing His hand to her breast, she asked again:

“‘Do not lie to me for fear of me. This is what I think: all You say is mere playfulness — You will run away without my knowing. You, Lord, are Your own master, never in another's power, and You do what pleases You. If You will take sannyasa — what can I say? [Only] tell me the truth.’” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, vv. 24–25)

Then the Lord smiled softly and said: “Listen, My beloved, do not grieve at all in your heart: what I say for your good, listen to attentively.” And He began to instruct her:

“All that you see in the world count as empty: Bhagavan alone is true, and true are the Vaishnavas; all else besides them count as empty. Empty are son, husband, wife, father, mother — all that goes by such names: in the end, who belongs to whom? Apart from Sri Krishna's feet there is no other kin; all that

you see is His maya. Whether woman or man — see: the soul of all is one [in nature]; only in the bonds of maya does one imagine 'two.' Sri Krishna is the husband of all, and all others are prakriti: this no one understands."[9] (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, vv. 27–29)

A person, He went on, is born of blood and seed in a place of filth, suffers from childhood to old age, priding himself on body and home; those he raised revile him, his hearing and sight grow dim, he weeps over his woes — and still he does not serve Govinda. He was given a body in order to serve Krishna, yet, forgetting that service, he paves his own way to hell. And the Lord concluded:

"Your name is Vishnupriya ('dear to Vishnu'): make it meaningful, do not keep needless grief in your heart. I have told you this — put away other thoughts and give your mind to the deeds of Krishna." (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, v. 33)

By this conversation Gaurasundara was teaching not Vishnupriya alone: His words are addressed to all living beings intoxicated with the thirst for enjoyment — the true husband of all is one, Krishna. So too was fulfilled what had been foretold of her name at the matchmaking: the name "Vishnupriya" was to become true.

Then the Lord, Himself the Master, drew back the veil of His yogamaya, which had hidden His divinity from her[10] — and her heart grew clear:

"Grief and sorrow went away, her breast filled with joy — and suddenly she sees [Him] four-armed." (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, v. 34)

Before her stood Narayana, the Supreme Lord, and the very vision told her: give up the grief born of maya. Her sorrow left her, and her heart filled with joy and wonder.

Yet even seeing the four-armed form, she did not give up thinking of Him as her husband. The form of Narayana, full of majesty, did not eclipse for her the One whom she had served at home; falling at His feet, she pleaded:

"'I, the lowest and most worthless, was born in this world, and You are my beloved husband, the Lord of my life; such was my good fortune — I had become Your maidservant — why then [now] such a fall?'" (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, v. 36)

Without serving You, she said, I shall perish — and she wept aloud. Seeing His beloved's anguish, the Lord, His eyes brimming with tears, took her in His arms, bestowed His grace on her[11] and said:

"'Listen, Vishnupriya-devi, this is what I tell you: whenever you think of Me — wherever I may go, I am with you; truly, truly I tell you firmly.'" (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, v. 38)

This promise the Lord kept: in separation He remained with her in His holy name and in the Deity whom she served all her life. Then she understood that the Lord is wholly independent:

"Hearing the word of Krishna's command, Vishnupriya thought: 'This Lord is the independent Master, He does what pleases Him — who can stand in His way?' — and she made no reply." (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, v. 39)

She lowered her face, her eyes brimming with tears[12], and the Lord spoke tender words to her. "It is painful to hear of the Lord's deeds," sighs Lochana Dasa. In this silence is the whole of Vishnupriya. She does not argue, does not hold Him back, does not become an obstacle on His path: she gives Him her grief as well. In taking sannyasa the Lord enters the mood of Radha parted from Krishna, and Vishnupriya's separation from Him is also a service to this vipralambha of His, His "pastime of separation."

Then, Lochana writes, days and nights went by in anxious surmise, "as if a fire had flared up in everyone's heart." Shachi and Vishnupriya wept day and night — "darkness on every side, all seems

empty.” Srivasa begged to be taken along; in the house of Murari Gupta the Lord privately told Murari to worship Advaita Acharya and, consoling him, said that the sannyasa was “not yet soon.”

Haridasa Shastri's edition (1983) — and before it the edition of 1903 — continues the story here with a section, “The Consolation of the Devotees,” which is not in Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's edition[13]. In those last days, according to this section, the Lord laid aside His absorption in renunciation and showed His love in every house: He gladdened His mother with words that set her heart at ease, jested and laughed with townsfolk and household, anointed Himself with sandal and wore ornaments. Those who had secretly meant to go with Him His yogamaya sent back home, and everyone concluded there would be no sannyasa. On the last night

“The Lord lay down in His chamber, and Vishnupriya came with a bunch of betel in her hand. Smiling with delight, the Lord says, ‘Come, come!’ — and with great tenderness seated her on His lap. Vishnupriya anointed the Lord's body with sandal and drew a tilaka with fragrant aguru and musk, put a divine garland of malati on Gora's body and with tender jests placed betel in His holy mouth. Then Mahaprabhu, the crown of connoisseurs of rasa, Himself began to adorn Vishnupriya.” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, vv. 68+9–68+13)

He braided her long hair and decked it with malati flowers, placed on her forehead a dot of sindura ringed with dots of sandal — “as if the moon had taken the sun onto its lap” — lined her eyes and adorned her. Further on Lochana Dasa speaks of the tenderness of that night in the images with which poetry sings of divine love, and himself cautions that this is “beyond the reach of Kama.”[14] And this is how the night ended:

“At the end of the night the Lord rose quickly; Vishnupriya sleeps a deep sleep. At the time of renunciation His prema surges higher still; with the thought ‘I shall take sannyasa’ His heart is as if maddened.” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, vv. 68+27–68+28)

Why at such an hour did the Lord unfold play, rasa and bhava? Lochana Dasa answers himself: the Lord repays each according to his service, but Krishna is captured only by prema full of anuraga — and Gaura, the ocean of mercy, Himself begs for such prema and Himself bestows it:

“In mercy He reveals His own anuraga, so that in separation her bhava may grow in her heart. ‘Whoever sees My body with bhava — with him My bhava is never broken.’ Who else is such a treasury of mercy, who gives prema and anuraga so as to bind His very Self? This is why [He showed] grace to Vishnupriya — knowing this, let no one go astray in mind.” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 15, vv. 68+35–68+38)

So the poet himself understands this night: not as worldly love, but as a grace by which the Lord deepened the prema of His eternal consort before her long years of separation. Yet Gaudiya Vaishnavas, following Vrindavana Dasa, see in the Gaura of Navadvipa a model of the strict propriety of a brahmana householder, and Srila Bhaktisiddhanta apparently left this section out of his edition deliberately: written in the spirit of nagari-bhava, it easily becomes a prop for the doctrine of gaura-nagari. That is why it is retold here only briefly, and only in the light of Lochana Dasa's own words.

Rising at dawn and performing His morning duties, Gaurahari settled His resolve: “I shall take sannyasa from Bharati Gosani in Kantakanagara.” Setting out, He noted that His breath was flowing through the right nostril — an auspicious sign. The Lord went to the Ganga[15]:

“Bowing to the Ganga, He leaves Navadvipa — as if a thunderbolt struck everyone on the head. As if the sun had hidden in the middle of the day, as if the swans had left the lake — where have they gone?” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 16, vv. 5–6)

Separation

Mahaprabhu was only twenty-four when He left for Katwa to take sannyasa. On learning that He had swum across the Ganga and gone to Keshava Bharati, Shachi and Vishnupriya fell senseless; Nityananda tried to console them. Later Chandrashekhara Acharya returned from Katwa with the news of the sannyasa, and both wept bitterly again (CM, Madhya-khanda, parts 16–18).

Lochana Dasa paints their grief thus:

“Shachi Devi weeps, holding Vishnupriya on her lap — and Vishnupriya lies as though dead: the body is there, but life has left it. Shachi and Vishnupriya weep, rolling on the ground.” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 16, vv. 10–11)

“Where have you run off to, abandoning Vishnupriya?” laments Shachi. “You have counted the love of all the devotees as nothing!” And Vishnupriya now rises, now falls, as if mad (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 16, vv. 21–22).

When Chandrashekhara returned, her grief grew still stronger:

“From Vishnupriya's weeping the earth splits; beasts, birds, creepers, trees — even the stones weep.” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 18, v. 15)

“‘Life does not leave my sinful body!’ — rolling on the ground, the Devi cries: ‘Alas, alas!’ Her breath bursts forth unceasingly, burning with the fire of separation; her lips are parched, her body trembles. Lying in the dust, she tends neither her hair nor her clothes; now her body wastes away, now it seems to swell. Now she loses consciousness, contemplating His crimson feet, now with great difficulty she comes to herself. Now she cries aloud: ‘Lord, Lord!’ — and at Vishnupriya's weeping everyone weeps.” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 18, vv. 26–30)

Those who came to console her burned in their own hearts and said: “‘The deeds of your Lord are not unknown to you: understand this and comfort your heart’” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 18, v. 33). Then the devotees remembered His former word — “Whoever takes My name will attain Me” — and then

“all sat down to chant the name — Shachi, Vishnupriya and all the rest, children and old people, young men and maidens — sat down to chant the name, making Gauranga their shelter.” (CM, Madhya-khanda, part 18, vv. 39–40)

So began for her the long years of separation. Her days, as the “Advaita-prakasha” describes them, began with a bath in the Ganga at dawn in Shachi's company; after that she kept within doors, hidden even from sun and moon. The devotees glimpsed no more of her than her feet and never heard her speak. Her only food was what Shachi left, and she became thin and pale. In solitude she spent the whole day chanting the holy name before a picture of Gauranga, which she served as the Lord Himself, surrendered at His feet. Such a life in separation shows what a devoted wife is, and what the forbearance is that the Lord praises in His own verse: “humbler than a blade of grass, more tolerant than a tree” (“trinad api sunichena”).

The Sacrifice of the Holy Name

She counted the holy name with grains of rice. On either side of her stood two clay pots — one with uncooked rice, the other empty — and after each complete utterance of the mantra of sixteen names and thirty-two syllables she moved one grain[16]; thus she chanted the name until three in the afternoon. The rice so gathered she cooked — she prepared no other food for herself — and, moistening it with her tears, offered it to Mahaprabhu, eating only a small portion herself, as much as was needed to sustain life. Even while honouring prasada she chanted the name in the mood of separation; giving up sleep and rest, she chanted it through all eight praharas, day and night, wholly immersed in the transcendent vipralambha-rasa — the taste of separation. So passed her days and nights.

The “Prema-vilasa” says: as Mahaprabhu chanted the name day and night without counting, so His beloved, “Ishvari Vishnupriya,” chanted it without pause; and this was within her power, for the Lord had placed in her the seed of His own potency.

The “Bhakti-ratnakara” (4.47–51), from the words of Srinivasa, who came to her every day, relates that her deeds are indescribable. She gave up sleep, and if she slept at all, it was on the bare ground; her body, once brighter than gold, grew dim, and she became as thin as the moon on the fourteenth night of the dark fortnight; she counted the names with grains, cooked them and offered them to the Lord, herself eating a morsel, and no one understood how she remained alive.

Thus by her separation she teaches the world: in the pastimes of Gaurasundara's separation she is the exemplary acharya, the teacher of the worship of the holy name. As after Nityananda's disappearance Jahnava carried out the work of an acharya, so Vishnupriya after Gaurasundara's disappearance lived in His house in Mayapur-Navadvipa and enacted the pastime of an acharya who teaches the service of Gaura's name, Gaura's abode and Gaura's desire — gaura-nama, gaura-dhama and gaura-kama.

The Deity of Mahaprabhu

It is said that Vishnupriya was the first to establish the worship of the form of Gauranga. Murari Gupta writes in the “Kadacha” (4.14.8) that Krishna in His manifest form came to His beloved, Himself created His murti and abided in it, and she, the form of Lakshmi, serves Him. While she was near Him, Mahaprabhu manifested Himself in the form of the Deity and instructed her: “In Him Krishna abides,” — and she served that Deity. Thus she was the first to reveal to the world the Deity of Vishvambhara and brought good to the world by singing the nectar of Gaura's name.

The devotees of Mahaprabhu also tell this differently. Sri Rama, who had vowed to have one wife only, performed a sacrifice in exile together with a golden image of Sita but did not marry again; in the same way, they say, Vishnupriya, in the pastimes of Gaura-Narayana, rendered her Lord what she owed Him: she commissioned a form of Mahaprabhu in order to worship Him with the offering of the holy name. Navadvipa still has this Deity, and His worship continues. At her wish the worship of the Deity of Mahaprabhu was established by Vamshivadana, and after her departure His service was moved to Kuliya, the present town of Navadvip; and when the descendants of Vamshi, having accepted Jahnava's mercy, settled in Baghnapara, the service in Kuliya remained with servitors from Malkhana[17].

Consoling His mother on the eve of sannyasa, the Lord promised her:

“Beginning this movement of sankirtana, I shall soon take two more births as your son.” (CB, Madhya 27.47)

Gaudiya commentators see in these words an indication that the Lord soon descends again — as the Deity-avatara (archa) and as the Name-avatara, for the name, the Deity and the Lord Himself are one, and all three are eternal consciousness and bliss. Vishnupriya served Him both in the name and in the Deity.

At almost the same time as her Deity was established, Gauridasa Pandita manifested in his house the Deities of Nityananda and Gaurachandra (Murari 4.14.12–14). The “Bhakti-ratnakara” names other Deities of Gaura too: the Gaura-Govinda of Kashishvara in Vrindavana (2.438–443), the Deity of Narahari Sarakara in Shrikhanda (8.431–432) and the Deity of Dasa Gadadhara in Katwa (8.453).

Srinivasa, Vamshivadana and Ishana

Soon after Mahaprabhu disappeared in Nilachala, Srinivasa came to Mayapur on the instruction of Gadadhara Pandita — he was travelling from Shrikhanda to Navadvipa to see Vishnupriya's feet (BR 4; “Prema-vilasa” 4.167). At the Yogapitha, in Mahaprabhu's house, he saw her and the old Vaishnava

Ishana, and there he also met her disciple Vamshivadana Dasa, who lived in Mayapur to serve her.

Vamshi, according to the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (4.20–24), guessed without any introduction that this was Srinivasa, embraced him, bathed him in tears, would not let him bow down, and went to inform “Ishvari Vishnupriya-Ma” of him cautiously[18]. At first she did not grant him darshana; only when Vamshi asked her again and again — seeing Srinivasa's despair — to receive and bless him, did she agree, and at her bidding Vamshi brought him[19]. Srinivasa fell to the ground with tears of love; in motherly affection Vishnupriya placed her feet on his head, blessed him, and told him to stay and take prasada. Thus he received the blessing of both her and Vamshi.

Srinivasa saw with his own eyes her service in separation and marvelled at her renunciation and faith. Having received her loving blessing and instructions, he went to Sita in Shantipur and then to Khardaha. Later Srinivasa, Narottama and other acharyas carried the sankirtana, having received the mercy and guidance not only of Jahnava but also of Vishnupriya — Gaura's shakti.

After the Lord's sannyasa Ishana Thakura took upon himself the care of Shachi, of Vishnupriya and of the house. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta, in the “Gaudiya-bhashya” on the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Madhya 8.73), says that by serving the Lord's mother and wife even after His sannyasa, Ishana became “the most blessed of the blessed.” For service to a devotee is higher than service to the Lord Himself: Ishana served Shachi and Vishnupriya and received their love, and the Lord's mercy comes by way of the devotee's. Ishana lived very long — he outlived Vishnupriya and all of Mahaprabhu's devotees in Navadvipa.

Beside him Vamshivadana Thakura was blessed with service: he became the servant and protector of Vishnupriya and Shachi. After Mahaprabhu's disappearance Vishnupriya took him as her servant, and, it is said, he was the first to receive her mercy; he was glorified as her “exclusive vessel of mercy,” and he was her disciple[20]. According to the “Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana,” Gadadhara Dasa too looked after Shachi and Vishnupriya in Navadvipa; when they were gone, he moved to Katwa and established a Deity of Gauranga there.

Departure

When, where and how Vishnupriya Devi left this world the biographies do not say. We know only that after the Lord's disappearance she lived in His house in Mayapur and that she outlived many: Gadadhara Dasa moved to Katwa only after the departure of Shachi and Vishnupriya, Vamshivadana moved her Deity after her departure, and Ishana outlived even her. The news of her departure in Navadvipa reached Srinivasa in Yajigrama, where he had returned with a chest of books after the events in Vishnupur; he fell senseless, and the devotees brought him round with difficulty.

The Bhu-shakti of Gaura-Narayana

Kavi Karnapura in the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” reveals who she and her father were in the eternal lila:

“Sri Sanatana Mishra is the former King Satrajit, whose daughter is Vishnupriya, the Mother of the world, the incarnation of Bhu.” (GGD 47)

The daughter of Satrajit whom Krishna married is Satyabhama; therefore in Krishna-lila Vishnupriya is called Satyabhama, the Lord's bhu-shakti. Karnapura finds confirmation in the “Chaitanya-chandrodaya,” where Kali says that the Lord, “taking as wife another, a partial incarnation of Bhu, named Vishnupriya…” (GGD 48); the same drama calls her “devotion itself embodied” — sakshat bhakti-svarupini.

But Gaudiya authors at once note a difference as well. Satyabhama is the lawful (svakiya) wife of Krishna, the Lord of Dvaraka, who has many wives, and a son was born to Krishna from her; in Vishnupriya's pastimes there is nothing of the kind, and Gaura-Narayana, the Lord of Mayapur, has no multitude of wives. Therefore on the path of reverence (maryada-marga) she is worshipped as Sri Lakshmi in the pastimes of Gaura-Narayana. Gaura-Narayana and Gaura-Vishvambhara are in essence one non-dual Truth, but in the manifestations of lila there is a difference between Them, and Their pastimes have different abodes.

Vrindavana Dasa compares her with Rukmini: the union of Vishnupriya and Nimai is like the union of Rukmini and Krishna (CB, Adi 15.59); Murari Gupta and Lochana Dasa say the same, and her father's good fortune is likened to that of Bhishmaka, Rukmini's father. For comparison: the father of the Lord's first consort, Vallabhacharya, is called by the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 10.48) and the “Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika” (44–45) both Janaka and Bhishmaka, and his daughter Lakshmipriya — Lakshmi, the single form of Janaki and Rukmini. And since both Satyabhama and Rukmini are manifestations of the daughter of Vrishabhanu, Sri Radha, Vishnupriya too may be called her manifestation — but, as will be said below, not Radha Herself.

Vishnu has three energies — Sri, Bhu and Nila (or Lila). In the pastimes of Gaura-Narayana the sri-shakti is Lakshmipriya, the bhu-shakti is Vishnupriya, and the third energy is Sri Navadvipa-dhama Herself[21]; all three are manifestations and maidservants of the supreme shakti, Sri Radhika. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta in the “Anubhashya” (on CC, Adi 1.37–45) explains: when Gaura shows His oneness with Narayana, His shaktis are His consorts Lakshmipriya and Vishnupriya; when with Krishna — Gadadhara Pandita, the Radha of Krishna-lila. Lakshmipriya, Vishnupriya and others are the shaktis of Gaura-Vasudeva, while Gadadhara Pandita, Svarupa Damodara and Ramananda Raya are the shaktis of madhura-rasa; and all of them assist Gaurasundara in His vipralambha, His mood of separation.

The change of consorts is explained in the same way. Before Gaurasundara revealed Himself as the incarnation of prema-bhakti, Lakshmipriya disappeared: while Vishnupriya — prema-bhakti embodied — was growing up, Lakshmipriya served Gaura-Narayana; but when this prema-bhakti had grown and become worthy of serving Gaurasundara, Lakshmipriya departed. As Navadvipa is the seat of the nine kinds of devotion, so Vishnupriya is ninefold devotion itself, the mistress of Gaura's home.

Gaurasundara is Radha and Krishna united in one form. Therefore Vishnupriya, the Mother of the world, who bestows love on the devotees, may be called a maidservant of Radha-Krishna, a devotee and companion (sahachari) of the daughter of Vrishabhanu — and Parameshvari. Srila Bhaktisiddhanta in one of his songs calls her the incarnation of prema-bhakti, Narayani, and says that, following the gopis, she served all three in her mind — Radha, Krishna and Gaura.

Gaura-nagari and the Sahajiyas

Vishnupriya's wedding, her conversation with the Lord before His sannyasa and her separation are subjects on which it is especially easy to stumble. The Gaudiya tradition — following Srila Bhaktisiddhanta — speaks of them directly and strictly, and without these warnings an account of her would be incomplete.

Into Lochana Dasa's “Chaitanya-mangala” self-interested people inserted the doctrine of gaura-nagari and various invented descriptions contrary to siddhanta; even some modern secular literary scholars acknowledge this. Into the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” and the “Chaitanya-charitamrita” nothing contrary to siddhanta has been inserted; therefore any view of another biography that cannot be reconciled with them is not accepted as true by the followers of Gaura.

The pastimes of Lakshmi and Narayana are not an attempt at enjoyment such as is natural to ordinary living beings. If an account of them is made the support of a false doctrine of enjoyment — the doctrine of gaura-nagari or of the prakrita-sahajiyas — this is a grave offence. In speaking with Vishnupriya before leaving home, Gaurasundara was teaching precisely those intoxicated with the thirst for enjoyment. And Lochana Dasa himself shows that pure devotees see in Vishnupriya not a trace of a possessive desire for enjoyment that might hinder the Lord's sannyasa; on the contrary, she nourished the joy of the independent Gaura-Vishvambhara — the pastime of separation of Vrajendra-nandana, imbued with Radha's bhava.

Those who distort Lochana Dasa's account and, displaying a seemingly great devotion to Vishnupriya, seek in their imagination to arrange her meeting with Gaurasundara in the Gambhira, in the house of Kashi Mishra in Nilachala, are great offenders at the feet of Gaurasundara and Vishnupriya, opponents of the siddhanta of pure devotion, prakrita-sahajiyas deserving censure. The same people write that Mahaprabhu, even after sannyasa, while living in Nilachala, bought cloth and other things and sent them to the wife of His former household life. In truth this is only the uncontrollable agitation of the inner enemies in those who write with a worldly mind and try to load their own worldly attachment onto the shoulders of Gaurasundara.

Various sects of “grihi-bauls,” householder bauls, paint invented pictures of Nimai's sannyasa, and some blame Sri Chaitanya for having, by taking sannyasa, abandoned His grown wife, violated dharma and caused a woman grief. They do not comprehend the words of the Vyasa of Chaitanya's pastimes:

“In truth all these examples of renunciation are not a rejection of one's obligations. At their root lies the attainment of the highest good, but only great souls can understand this. Even a hard tree melts on hearing of these divine pastimes, which bring liberation to all living beings.” (CB, Madhya 3.104–105)

Nor may the two lilas be confused. Those who call Vishnupriya “the original Radha” (amshini), and Gaura and Vishnupriya “Radha and Krishna,” erase the distinctive features of both lilas and commit a grave offence in both. Gaurasundara, adorned with Radha's bhava and radiance, is nowhere a “nagara” — a lover-gallant.

Bhaktivinoda Thakura wholly rejected the doctrines of “gaura-bhaja,” “gaura-vadi,” “gaura-nagari” and those mixed with “theosophy” — doctrines which, abandoning the path of Rupa's followers, merely imitated the worship of Vishnupriya and Gauranga — and preached the worship of Gaurasundara on the pure path of the rupanugas. Where the worship of Krishna together with the ashraya-vigraha — taught by Rupa, Raghunatha, Jiva, Krishnadasa Kaviraja and Narottama — is abandoned, and Gaura and Vishnupriya, under the guise of worshipping them, are honoured as separate from Krishna, there is neither Vishnupriya, the bhu-shakti, nor her Lord Gaurasundara. The worship of Gaura and Vishnupriya is genuine only on the path of the rupanugas — as part of the service of Radha and Krishna.

The Worship of Gaura and Vishnupriya

The true form of this worship was revealed by Narottama Dasa Thakura. He dispelled the misconception that Gaurasundara is not Vishnu but a living being within varnashrama, a “bhagavad-bhakta,” a “so-called great man” or merely a guru — the founder of one of the sampradayas — and in Kheturi he revealed the bhu-shakti Vishnupriya together with Gaura-Narayana. There she assists Gaurasundara's separation, whose form in separation is imbued with the bhava of the gopis; in Their relationship there is no sambhoga, no pastime of union: she serves His separation.

From his guru Lokanatha Gosvami Narottama had received the order to establish Deities of Radha-Krishna and Gauranga. Returning to Kheturi, he prepared five pairs of Radha-Krishna Deities, while the Deities of Gaura and Vishnupriya he obtained miraculously. The night before he received an

instruction in a dream, and in the morning he went to the neighbouring village of Gopalpur and wished to enter the granary of the brahmana Vipradasa, full of rice. People tried to dissuade him: venomous snakes hissed there, which even snake-charmers had failed to drive out. But when Narottama came and the granary was opened, the snakes vanished, and the Deities of Gaura and Vishnupriya, before everyone's eyes, came of Themselves onto his lap[22]; at once a great kirtana began. The "Bhakti-ratnakara" (10.202) says: "Gaurasundara and His beloved Vishnupriya came out of the granary and sat on Narottama's lap." Narottama took these Deities to Kheturi and installed Them there; today They are served in Gambhila[23].

At the great festival in Kheturi, on Phalguni Purnima, Narottama revealed six Deities: Gauranga with Vishnupriya, Vallabhikanta, Krishna, Vrajamohana, Radhakanta and Radharamana (BR 10, 12; "Prema-vilasa" 19; "Narottama-vilasa" 6). It is said that in Shrikhanda too, by the order of Narahari Sarakara, Raghunandana's son Kanai Thakura revealed the service of Gauranga and Vishnupriya.

Three centuries later this service was revived by Bhaktivinoda Thakura. In 1892 (the 20th of Phalguna, 1299 of the Bengali era), at a meeting in Mayapur, Jagannatha Dasa Babaji proposed that Jagannatha Mishra and Shachi be worshipped in one building and Mahaprabhu with Lakshmi and Vishnupriya at His sides in another; the Pancha-tattva in Srivasa-angana. In January 1894 a meeting convened by Bhaktivinoda at the A. B. school in Krishnanagar resolved to establish Deities at the Lord's birthplace; the "Navadvipa-pracharini-sabha" was founded, and Dvarakanath-babu, Naphar-babu and others resolved to build a hut there for the Deities of Gaura and Vishnupriya. On Friday, 21 March 1894 (the 9th of Chaitra, 1300 of the Bengali era), on Phalguni Purnima, during a lunar eclipse, amid loud kirtana, the Deities of Gaura and Vishnupriya were installed; for Their service the committee "Sri Mayapur Seva Samiti" was formed, joined by many well-known people. Thus Bhaktivinoda — following Narottama and with the permission of Jagannatha Dasa Babaji — revealed the service of Gaurasundara with Vishnupriya in Gaura's home in Mayapur.

The meaning of this service Srila Bhaktisiddhanta expressed in a song appended to his "Anuvritti" on the "Upadeshamrita." Some, he says, call for worshipping Vishnupriya all one's life, abandoning the path of Rupa and the service of Radha-Krishna, following "theosophy" and worldly enjoyment — such people have no association with Raghunatha, the rupanuga. Narottama, however, dispelling the world's delusion, established Gaura and Vishnupriya, while he himself, remembering Radha and Krishna, worshipped Them with all his heart in Vraja. The new doctrine of nagari, stricken by Kali, destroys bhakti; but Bhaktivinoda, the servant of Gaura at the feet of his Prabhupada, remembering the feet of Narottama, established Priya and Hari in Mayapur as his duty.

Srila Bhaktisiddhanta also chose the day of Vishnupriya's appearance to re-establish the "Vishva-vaishnava-raja-sabha": this took place amid kirtana on 5 February 1919 at the Ultadanga Math, the Bhaktivinoda-asana, and the "Amrita Bazar Patrika" wrote about it[24].

Significance

The life of Vishnupriya Devi is service to the Lord in two forms: at home, as Lakshmi beside Gaura-Narayana, and in separation, as the acharya of the holy name, serving Him in the name and in the Deity. By her mercy the worldly life ruled by the relation of "enjoyer and object of enjoyment," born of the worldly distinction of man and woman, falls away, and there awakens the longing to enter Gaura's home and to serve, even as a broom, in the marketplace of the holy name (nama-hatta) of Nityananda and of Sach-chid-ananda Bhaktivinoda. By her mercy the dharma of attachment to home (grihavrata) is torn out by the root, and one gains entry into Gaura's home in Yoga-Mayapur — and love for it.

1. According to other information, Vishnupriya was the daughter of the priest (purohita) of a local zamindar.

2. In the opinion of some, Durgadasa Mishra was not the grandfather but the father of Vishnupriya.

3. According to one biography — two or three times a day.

4. “Kulaka” in this verse is not a name but the word for “matchmaker”; one biography takes it as the brahmana's name. Another, retelling the “Chaitanya-mangala,” calls the matchmaker Dvija Kashishvara; but in the poem itself he is Kashinatha, “the best of brahmanas” (Adi-khanda, part 13, vv. 5, 8, 25), and so too in Murari Gupta (“Kadacha” 1.13.2–7); Srila Bhaktisiddhanta in his summary of this chapter calls him Kashinatha Mishra.

5. The order is given differently: in the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Adi 15.176–178) the exchange of garlands comes first, then the flowers; one biography in its own retelling names the flowers first and then the garlands.

6. The words “whoever hears of the Lord's wedding is freed from the bonds of the world; Lakshmi sat beside the Lord, and Shachi's house was filled with light” are sometimes cited as verses of the “Chaitanya-bhagavata,” Adi 10.110–111. That passage of the CB, however, concerns the Lord's first marriage — to Lakshmipriya; the passage close in meaning about the second marriage is Adi 15.214: “When Lakshmi and Narayana sat down, the whole house was filled with joyful cries.”

7. The 1983 edition has one more couplet here (v. 11+1), found neither in Bhaktisiddhanta's edition nor in that of 1903: “There is no other young woman as fortunate as I: You are my beloved Lord of life; great were my love and hope — I gave myself to You.”

8. Vishnupriya is the Lord's eternal consort, His bhu-shakti, and His tenderness towards her is the pastime of Narayana with His own energy, not a worldly intimacy in which one seeks enjoyment for oneself (see below, “Gaura-nagari and the Sahajiyas”). The playful “who ever told you that?” is also part of the lila: His intention is hidden for the time being by yogamaya.

9. “Empty” here means “transient, vain,” not “illusory” in the sense of Mayavada: the world is real as the Lord's energy, but all in it apart from Bhagavan and the Vaishnavas is perishable. Likewise “the soul in all is one” is not monism: all souls are one in nature, for all are the Lord's energy (prakriti) and in themselves neither men nor women; the seeming “two” arises from identification with the body. The only Purusha, the enjoyer, is Krishna.

10. The “Chaitanya-mangala” says “maya”: here this is yogamaya, the Lord's internal energy, which for the sake of the lila hid His divinity from Vishnupriya. The Lord is not subject to maya; the “grief born of maya” is Vishnupriya's grief, not ignorance on the Lord's part.

11. So in the “Chaitanya-mangala”; in one of the biographies that retell it, the Lord only bestows on Vishnupriya a merciful glance, “as if embracing her with His eyes.”

12. In the “Chaitanya-mangala” and in one biography Vishnupriya only thinks this to herself and makes no reply; in another biography she says it to the Lord aloud — “let no one become an obstacle to Your mission” — and only then falls silent.

13. This section (part 15, vv. 68+1–68+39) is not in the edition of Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati (1922); it is found in Haridasa Shastri's edition (1983), under the heading “The Consolation of the Devotees,” and in the 1903 edition. In our translation of the “Chaitanya-mangala” it is rendered in its place with a note, like all the additions of the 1983 edition; it does not carry the weight of the text accepted by Bhaktisiddhanta.

14. Here Lochana Dasa calls the Lord “the playful Nagara” (v. 68+23). This poetic word gives no support to the doctrine of gaura-nagari: Gaurasundara, adorned with the mood and lustre of Radha, is not a “nagara,” a gallant lover (see below, “Gaura-nagari and the Sahajiyas”); and the poet himself cautions that the love of the Lord and His shakti transcends mundane desire.

15. According to the “Chaitanya-bhagavata” (Madhya 28.41–50), on that night the Lord, having spent the evening with the devotees, took His supper and went to His bedroom, while Haridasa and Gadadhara lay down nearby; Shachi, knowing that He would leave, did not sleep but wept. Four dandas before dawn the Lord rose; Gadadhara begged to go with Him; Shachi sat down by the door, and the Lord, taking her hands, consoled her at length. Of Vishnupriya on that night Vrindavana Dasa says nothing.

16. So according to the “Prema-vilasa”; one biography writes otherwise — that she set aside one grain for each round (mala) of the Hare Krishna mantra, and in the evening cooked this rice and offered it to her Deity of Mahaprabhu.

17. Accounts of the Deity's later history differ. According to some, Vamshivadana established His worship at her wish during her lifetime; according to others, Vamshi after her departure moved the Deity to Koladvipa (the present town of Navadvip) and instituted His service there; according to a third account, after her departure the service was moved to Kuliya-Paharpur (printed “Phuliya”).

18. According to one biography — “Vishnupriya and Shachimata.” But the same biography says at once that Vamshi served Vishnupriya and Ishana after the departure of both Mahaprabhu and Shachi, that is, Shachi was no longer living by then; the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (4.20–24) names Vishnupriya alone.

19. So in one biography; according to another, Vamshi, seeing Srinivasa's despair, himself asked Vishnupriya to receive and bless him — nothing is said of her first refusing.

20. When Vamshi began to serve her is told differently: according to some — after Mahaprabhu's disappearance, according to others — only after the departure of both Mahaprabhu and Shachi.

21. Here the sources differ in wording: according to one explanation, Sri Navadvipa-dhama is the lila-shakti, according to another — the nila-shakti; in Srila Bhaktisiddhanta's song Nila Devi is the Dhama and Lakshmi Devi is Lakshmipriya, and all three shaktis serve Radha and Krishna.

22. The details are told differently: according to some biographies, a single venomous snake lived in the granary, and the Deities of Themselves sat on Narottama's lap (so too in the “Bhakti-ratnakara”); according to another, many snakes hissed there, and the Deities came of Themselves into his hands.

23. One biography, speaking of the Deity in Gambhila, at once calls these Deities “Sri Gauranga and Nityananda,” which disagrees both with the “Bhakti-ratnakara” (10.202) and with the other testimonies.

24. One biography gives the date 5 February and says at once that the newspaper wrote about it “on the next day, 10 February”; one of the two dates is evidently mistaken.